



POSTER FOR PARIS EXPOSITION

At the Exposition Universelle in 1889, Ravel was inspired by new Russian music and the exotic sounds of the Javanese gamelan.

Emergent talent

Music played a large part in the Ravel household—both classical and the folk songs that Maurice's mother sang. Maurice showed musical talent from an early age, began piano lessons at age seven, then went on to more serious studies in music theory, including his first attempts at composing, when he was 12. In the course of his studies, he met the young Spanish pianist Ricardo Viñes, who was to become a close friend, as well as a champion of Ravel's music.

The year 1889 was eventful for Ravel. He started piano lessons with Émile Decombes, a teacher at the Paris Conservatoire, who encouraged the young musician to give his first public